

Chapter – 7: India's Cultural Roots

That which cannot be stolen; that which cannot be confiscated by rulers; ... that which is not a burden as it does not weigh anything; that which, though it is used, only grows every day — that is the greatest wealth of all, the wealth of true knowledge.” — Subhāṣita (Wise Saying)

- Indian culture – several millenniums old – many roots and many branches
- Roots – nurture – common trunk – emerge – many branches – diff. manifestations – Indian culture – YET – united – common trunk
- Some branches – art, literature, science, medicine, religion, governance, martial arts, etc.
- Also – schools of thoughts – grp. of thinkers (**spiritual seekers**) – share – similar ideas – human life, world, etc.
- Many archaeologists – believe – India's cultural roots – all the way – Harappan civilisation
- Later on – 100s of schools of thoughts emerged – understand them better – understand 'India, that is Bharat' better

The Vedas and Vedic Culture

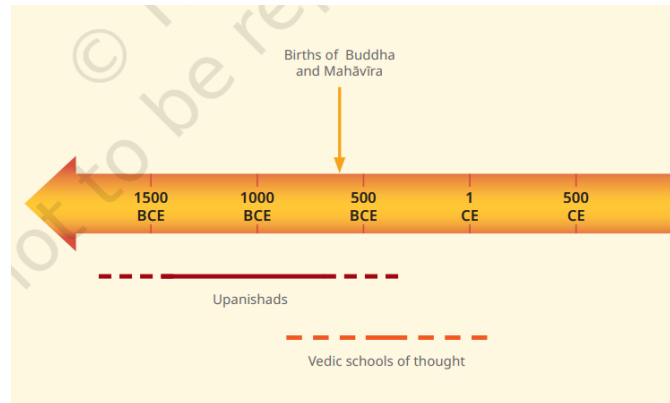
What are Vedas?

- Veda – origin – Sanskrit – *vid* – meaning – knowledge (*vidya*)
- 4 Vedas – Rig Veda, Yajur Veda, Sama Veda, Atharva Veda – most ancient text – India – even world
- Vedas – 1000s of hymns – prayers – form of poems and songs – recited orally – not written
- These hymns – composed – Sapta Sindhava region
- Difficult to say – when exactly composed – Rig Veda – most ancient – experts – propose – dates – 5th to 2nd Millennium BCE
- b/w – 100 to 200 generations – these texts – committed to memory – rigorous training – passed on orally
- Vedic hymns – composed by rishis (male seers or sages) OR rishikas (female ones) – early form – Sanskrit language
- Addressed to deities – Indra, Agni, Varuna, Mitra, Sarasvati, Ushas, many more – poetical form
- Together with seers – deities sustained *ritam* – truth and order – human life and universe
- Early rishis and rishikas – gods and goddesses – one entity – not separate –
 - ekam sat viprā bahudhā vadanti ...
 - The Existent [that is, the supreme reality] is one, but sages give it many names.
- In this **worldview** – some values – essentially imp. – truth – another name for God
- Rig Veda – last verses – call for unity –
 - Come together, speak together; common be your mind, may your thoughts agree ... United be your purpose, united your heart ... may your thoughts be united, so all may agree!

Vedic Society

- Early Vedic Society – organized – diff. *janas* (clans) – larger grp. of people
- Rig Veda – lists – over 30 such *janas* – the Bharatas, the Purus, the Kurus, the Yadus, the Turvashas, etc.
- Each clan – associated to – particular region – northwest region – Indian subcontinent
- *Janas* – governed how – not much known
- Vedas – few clues – words – *raja* – king or ruler – *sabha*, *samiti* – collective gathering or assembly

- Vedic texts – many professions – agriculturist, weaver, potter, builder, carpenter, healer, dancer, barber, priest, etc.



Vedic schools of thought

- Vedic culture – developed many rituals – *yajna* (yagya) – directed towards – deities – individual, collective well-being
- Daily rituals – generally – prayers, offerings to Agni – deity associated to fire – rituals – become more complex with time
- Grp. of texts – Upanishads – based on Vedic concepts – ALSO – introduced new ones
 - Rebirth – taking birth again and again
 - Karma – action and their results
- A/c to 1 school of thought – Vedanta – everything – human, nature, universe – 1 divine essence – *brahman* (do not confuse with God Brahma) – OR – *tat* (that)
- 2 mantras – express – simple way –
 - aham brahmāsmi
 - “I am brahman” (that is to say, I am divine)
 - tat tvam asi...
 - “You are That”
- Upanishads – introduced – concept – *atman* (self) – divine essence – present – every being – BUT – ultimately – one with *brahman*
- Everything – connected and interdependent – explains – common prayer – *sarve bhavantu sukhinah* – may all creatures be happy – goes on – with them all to be free of diseases
- Early – 1st millennium BCE – several more schools of thought – grew – based on Vedas
- One of them – Yoga – developed methods – achieve *brahman* – within oneself
- Together – schools of thought – foundations for Hinduism
- Many stories – Upanishads – importance of asking ques. – whoever asks – men, women, children

Shvetaketu and the seed of reality – Chandogya Upanishad

- Rishi Uddalaka Aruni – sent his son – Shvetaketu – to gurukula – learn Vedas
- After 12 yrs. – Shvetaketu – returned – very proud – his learning
- Father – asked questions – nature of *brahman* – Shvetaketu couldn’t answer
- Uddalaka – explained – *brahman* – invisible – YET – everywhere
 - Seed – banyan fruit – empty when opened – BUT – contains future tree
 - Same clay – diff. pots can be made
- Everything around us – same essence – *brahman*
- Ended his teaching by saying – ‘Everything consists of subtle essence, you are that, Shvetaketu’

Nachiketa and his quest – *Katha Upanishad*

- A man – giving away – all possessions – ritual
- His son – Nachiketa – kept asking – which god – he would be offered to
- Father angrily answered – I give you to Yama – God of death
- Nachiketa – went to Yama’s world – waited long – met the mighty God
- One question on his mind – what happens after death of body
- Yama – hesitated to answer – BUT – boy – very persistent
- Yama explained – *atman* (self) – hidden in all creatures – neither born nor dies – immortal
- After – acquiring this knowledge – Nachiketa – returned home – father welcomed joyfully

The debate of Gargi and Yajnavalkya – *Brihadaranyaka Upanishad*

- Wise king – Janaka – announced prize – winner – philosophical debate
- Yajnavalkya – renowned rishi – defeated many scholars
- Gargi – a rishika – asked him – series of questions – nature of world and *brahman*
- Yajnavalkya – asked her – stop questioning
- Later – she asked anyway – Yajnavalkya – explained – *brahman* – makes the world, seasons, rivers, everything else – possible

Buddhism

- Other schools of thought – emerged – did not accept – authority of Vedas – developed – own systems – one of them – Buddhism
- 2 ½ millenniums ago – young prince – Siddhartha Gautama – born in Lumbini (Nepal)
- Depending on src. – scholars – widely diff. conclusions – precise year of birth
- Ch. 4 – 560 BCE – approx. yr. – no diff. – this story
- Siddhartha Gautam – protected life – palace
- One day – age 29 – asked – to be driven around – 1st time in life – came across – old man, sick man, dead body – ALSO – ascetic (someone – rigorous discipline – attain higher consciousness) – happy and at peace
- Siddhartha – decided – give up palace life – leave behind wife and son
- Travel on foot – as an ascetic – meeting other ascetics, scholars – searched for root cause – suffering
- After meditating – many days – under peepal tree – Bodhi Gaya (Bihar) – attained enlightenment
- He realized – *avidya* (ignorance), attachment – root cause – human suffering – created a method – remove these 2 causes
- Siddhartha – became ‘Buddha’ – meaning – enlightened OR awakened
- Started teaching – what he realized – incl. – idea of ahimsa – generally translated to non-violence – BUT – originally meant – non-hurting OR non-injuring
- Also insisted – sincere inner discipline – following expression – explains simply –
 - “Not by water is one made pure, though many people may bathe here [in sacred rivers]. But one is pure in whom truth and dharma reside. Conquering oneself is greater than conquering a thousand men on the battlefield a thousand times.”
- Buddha – founded Sangha – community – *bhikshus* (**monks**) – later – *bhikshunis* (**nuns**) – dedicated themselves – practice and spread – his teachings
- His influence – India, even whole of Asia – enormous – still perceptible today

Jainism

- Another imp. school of thought – widespread – same time – BUT – roots – much more ancient

- Prince Vardhamana – born in royal family – early 6th century BCE
- Birthplace – near Vaishali city – modern-day Bihar
- Age 30 – decided – leave home – search – spiritual knowledge
- Practiced – ascetic discipline – after 12 yrs. – achieved – supreme wisdom
- Became – Mahavira (great hero) – started preaching – what he realized
- Jain – comes from – *jina* – meaning – conqueror
 - Not the conquest – territory or enemies – BUT – conquest of ignorance and attachments – to reach enlightenment
- Jain teachings – include –
 - Ahimsa – All breathing, existing, living, sentient creatures – not to be slain, nor treated with violence, nor abused, nor tormented, nor driven away.”
 - *Anekantavada* – truth – many aspects – cannot be described fully – single statement
 - *Aparigraha* – detachment – material possessions – limit yourself – what is truly necessary
- These ideas – shared with Buddhism and Vedic school of thought – central to Indian culture
- Jainism – insists – interconnectedness, interdependence – all creatures – support each other – cannot exist – without each other
- Scientists – studying nature – confirmed – this deep truth

The Jataka Tales

- Delighted generations – Indian children and adults – tell stories – Buddha’s former births – express Buddhist values – simpler ways
- Well-known tale – Buddha – king – large grp. of monkeys – lived near – huge tree – fruit – divine fragrance and taste
- Monkey-king – instructions – now fruit – escape – BUT – 1 fruit – fell into river
- Carried by current – caught in a net – taken to palace
- King – liked the taste – ordered soldiers – locate tree
- After – long search – found the tree – monkeys – enjoying fruit
- Only way – monkey-king – save monkeys – cross the stream – difficult for them
- Monkey-king – much larger – caught the tree – used his own body as bridge – help others – cross the stream – BUT – bruised too much – eventually died
- Human king – watched from dist. – greatly moved – monkey-king’s selfless sacrifice
- Understood – role of king – respect to subjects

A Jain Story

- Rohineya – very skilled burglar – never got caught
- On his way to city – accidentally heard – few sentences – sermon – Mahavira – achieving liberation from ordinary life of ignorance
- Reaching city- Rohineya – recognised and caught – pretended to be farmer
- Minister – developed a plan – force him – confess
- Rohineya – remember Mahavira’s word – detect the plan – defeat it
- Felt remorseful – approached Mahavira – confessed – returned the stolen items – asked for forgiveness
- Became a monk – realized the illusion – living in – focused – acquiring higher knowledge
- The story – shows – importance – right action, right thinking – also shows – everyone deserves second chance
- Both – Buddhism, Jainism – monks and nuns – travel across – spread their teachings

- Some – created monasteries – others – lived ascetic lives – rock-cut caves
- Archaeological findings – revealed traces – monasteries – even names of monks – lived there



- Other – school of thoughts – also present
- Example –
 - Charvaka (Lokayata) – believed – material world – only thing – no life – after death
 - Was not popular – disappeared after some time
- Wide diversity – intellectual, spiritual belief systems – people – free to choose – what suited them
- Vedic, Buddhist, Jain schools – imp. diff. – BUT – common concepts as well – dharma, karma, rebirth, search to end suffering – trunk of the tree

Folk and Tribal Roots

- Cultural roots – studied so far – well documented – texts
- India – rich oral traditions – teachings, prayers – transmitted through daily practice – no written texts
- Among them –
 - Numerous folk traditions – transmitted by normal people
 - Tribal traditions – transmitted by tribes

What is a Tribe?

- Many definitions – social entity
- Today – anthropologists – tribe – grp. of families, clans – share – common descent, culture, language – living – close-knit community – under a chief – no private prop.
- Ancient India – no word for tribe – instead – tribe – just *janas* – specific env.
- Constitution of India – terms – tribes OR tribal community (English) – *janjati* (Hindi)
- A/c to off. fig. – 2011 India – 705 tribes – most states – amounting to 104 million population – more than entire Australia and United Kingdom together
- 19th century – anthropologists – studying tribes – referred to them – primitive, inferior
- Deeper studies – tribal communities – rich, complex culture – biased judgement – mostly abandoned
- Const. interaction – b/w folk and tribal traditions and leading schools of thought
- Deities, concepts, legends, rituals – freely exchanged – both dir.
- Example – Jagannath – worshipped at Puri (Odisha) – originally – tribal deity – also – many mother-goddess – worshipped across India
- Some tribes – adopted Hindu deities – long time ago – own versions – Mahabharata, Ramayana – well documented – all the way – northeastern states to Tamil Nadu
- Folk, tribal, Hindu belief systems – many similar concepts
- All 3 – elements of nature – mountains, rivers, trees, plants, animals, stones – sacred – consciousness behind them

- Toda tribals – Nilgiris, Tamil Nadu – 30+ peaks – home – Gods, Goddesses – so sacred – avoid pointing with finger
- Despite – multiplicity of deities – like Hinduism – many tribal grp. – concept – higher divinity
- Example –
 - Arunachal Pradesh – several tribes – worship Donyipolo – combined form – Sun and Moon – later – ascended – supreme god
 - Khandoba – several parts of India – similar situation
 - Eastern India – Munda, Santhal tribals – worship Singbonga – supreme deity – created the whole world
- Result – long interaction – mutual enrichment
- Folk, tribal beliefs – count among – India's cultural roots